

Eleven Features of Vim That You Probably Aren't Using



For developers and other users of Vim, here's a list of useful features and commands of Vim editor for same.

If you have a basic knowledge of Vim and are interested in exploring some advanced ways to use it, but think you may be missing some essential features of the GUI-based editor, this article is for you.

1. Word suggestion

Sometimes, when writing programs, you do need suggestions of variable/function names from the IDE. This is possible with Vim. In insert mode, type the first couple of characters of a word, then press:

- `Ctrl-N` to insert the next matching word
- `Ctrl-P` to insert the previous matching word

For a programmer, this is very useful when entering the names of variables in a program.

Incidentally, if you really want `CTRL-P` or `CTRL-N` to scan a dictionary file, then try `:set dictionary=/usr/`. Multiple dictionaries can be used as well.

2. Find the next or previous occurrence of the word under the cursor

Sometimes, it's useful to find the next or previous occurrence of a word in your file. This is possible with Vim. In command mode, hit `#'` or `**` to find the previous or next occurrence of the word that is under the cursor.

3. Undo recent changes

To undo changes, the `'u'` command is used. In command mode,

hitting `'u'` will undo the last change.

4. The % key

This is a really awesome feature for programmers. The `%` key can be used for the following:

- To jump to a matching opening or closing parenthesis, square bracket or a curly brace: `{ [ { }`
- To jump to the start or end of a C-style comment: `/* */`.
- To jump to a matching C/C++ pre-processor conditional: `#if, #ifdef, #else, #elif, #endif`.

In command mode, press `'%'` to find the matching brace/comment that is under the cursor.

5. Repeat the previous action

The `'.'` command repeats the last change made in normal mode. For example, if you press `dw` to delete a word, you can then press `'.'` to delete another word.

6. Open multiple windows in Vim

It is a basic requirement for any programmer to open multiple files concurrently. Vim supports this too.

Vim has the ability to split its window into multiple panes using the `:sp` or `:vsp` commands.

To open a different file in a newly split window, you can specify the filename as part of the command. For a horizontal split, use `:sp <filename>` and for a vertical split, use `:vsp <filename>`.